Experience and Changes: Interview with the 79th Youth Governor

Over the years, thousands of high school students across California have assumed simulated government roles in California's legislative and judicial systems through the Model Legislative & Court (MLC) program, which meets weekly. We debate issues, advocate in court, and work on bills and proposals across our program areas. With the end of the 78th MLC, we elected the new "Big Three" leadership— Youth Governor, Secretary of State, and Chief Justice—during our major experiences of Camp Bob and SAC, involving an all-delegation gathering.

To get more insights into conceivable changes happening in MLC in the upcoming year, I sat down with the newly elected 79th Youth Governor, Devon Jasiukonis. Devon is from the Anderson Munger Delegation, which is the delegation I joined this year. It's exciting to anticipate what he could bring to this program, which serves over 2,000 students across California, either through program areas or direct support for delegates.

Taken from Devon's experience from the 7th-grade Model United Nations (MUN) to MLC, what drives him is the peer-led environment and the inclusive community they built up together. To him, Youth and Government is really a third space to interact with people outside of the school context through icebreakers, debates, and shaping experiences and lessons together. The AMY delegation started with only 14 people to almost 81 people. The growth in engagement by numbers also reflects the personal growth of Devon, as it creates a larger platform for him to practice to make perfect, using his voice. Through this platform, it shaped him from feeling nervous to speak in front of almost 2000 delegates from different delegations all over California to a speaker and leader who empowers the group and works to change the community.

With the emphasize of MLC in understanding the governmental process, the major participation in delegations and conferences are joining program areas, for example, Devon has engaged in Appellate Court, which focuses on the legislative and court aspects with a smaller team to bond with; Constitutional Convention; and Campaign Strategy, which is the newest program at SAC for the four candidates who are running for Youth Governor. As Campaign Strategy, which really models the actual government, is his most resonating program area so far, he thinks that all of the areas build family throughout the year and strengthen this connection during the two weekends at Camp Bod and SAC, since each of them has designated tasks like writing bills or proposals. This is most emphasized in Campaign Strategy, where Devon and his campaign teams have the initiative to figure out and plan what to work on during the whole SAC weekend, with their campaign managers selected during Camp BOB.

As for me, who participated in the Special Interest Committee and was elected as one of the Special Interest Committee Chairs, it was an immersive experience to have for practicing debate skills, proposal writing ability, and connections with other delegates who could be yearlong friends. Identifying national-level concerns and being peer judges really strengthened my understanding of government and the process.

After gaining a sense of what this year's programs, which, according to Devon, had revolutionized the legislative process in this program and the past programs, looked like, there are more changes and implementations of new program areas and policies in the upcoming year, including the Government Advisory Council (GAC), the Local Government program, and the Environmental Protection policy. The two areas stemmed from Devon's observation of the division between the leadership and delegates in this program, since most of the decision-making is more often discussed between officers. Therefore, GAC provides a face-to-face communicative chance for delegates who are not the President or Vice President of their delegation but still want to make an influence through sharing personal perspectives or the changes they foresee, ensuring that the MLC gets voices from not only the leadership or the CalY, but from the delegates who immerse themselves in this journey. The Local Government Program is all tied back to Devon's emphasis on building connections between delegations and delegates outside of the conference, because even when the experiences at Camp Roberts and SAC constructed the unity of delegations throughout the weekend, once we leave, there are boundaries between us, and we work on bills or proposals separately in our own delegations.

Other focuses of this new term are Devon's highlights on environmental protection and economic equality. "It is important to invest more in sustainable energy in agriculture and promote economic equality," he states, "especially in California." Through lobbying for bills that make efforts to protect the environment by reducing California greenhouse gas emissions and to promote equality in fair wages, affordable housing, and access to education, he wishes to enforce these goals, not just set them.